European coloniser with non-Christian idol-worshipping societies in turn led to the justification of ‘liberation’ and ‘civilisation’ being offered for the colonisation of a religiously and, hence, racially inferior people. This ultimately paved the way for institutionalised slavery and an economy based on it.[16] Mignolo too echoed these thoughts in his paper titled ‘Racism as We Understand It Today’ in which he charted the Christian OET-driven origins of the European coloniser’s obsession with race/ethnicity.[17]

Building on the works of Quijano and Wynter, Nelson Maldonado-Torres suggested that religion as an anthropological category and race as an organising principle of human identification and social organisation were the products of European colonialism, which only expanded with the growth of Western modernity.[18] According to him, both religion and race were constituted together and became two of the most central categories that altered global history at every level. Therefore, the critical theory of religion was highly relevant to understanding the critical theory of race, and both were relevant to understanding the evolution of ethics. In essence, any understanding of coloniality/modernity was incomplete without applying the twin lenses of religion and race, and the only way to present an alternative foundation for ethics was to adopt a decolonial approach, given the near-complete hegemony of coloniality and modernity on contemporary ideas of ethics.

According to Torres, the Age of Discovery necessitated the broadening of the understanding of European conceptions of religion when the Christian European coloniser came into contact with non-Christian indigenous societies of the New World. Citing the work of Guy Stroumsa, an Israeli scholar of religious studies, Torres took the view that the Age of Discovery prompted a new approach to religion in view of Christianity’s encounter with Amerindians; this is what makes the Age of Discovery relevant for understanding the emergence of the modern categories of religion and race. According to him, this was a major ‘epistemic revolution’ in its own right. He also felt that the link between race and religion was better understood by taking into account Christianity’s theological conceptions of Judaism, given its attempts to sever itself from its Jewish racial roots, as well as its perceptions of Islam. For a more comprehensive understanding of the race–religion interplay, he suggested the inclusion of perceptions of blackness (namely the perceived link between race, colour and the existence of a soul) and indigeneity as well.